

# Session 45: Reflecting on the Ending of Jonah

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## Key Takeaways

- The mercy of God is remarkable. It is given to our enemies and also to us when we struggle with the fact that God loves our enemies.
- The meaning of Jonah is clear, and we can all agree on it no matter our different views about the historical reference of the events in the book.

## The Sense of an Ending

“The narrative of Jonah’s story lacks closure, a sense of completion, and a sense that nothing necessary has been omitted from the work. The book ends without a resolution to the major conflict of the narrative’s plot. The reader experiences the greatest sense of closure at the end of the third chapter as Nineveh repents and God forgives. Even the fourth chapter begins by providing closure regarding Jonah’s flight, but the book’s final scene immediately reopens that closure just experienced by the reader. God’s question concludes the book, leaving Jonah’s response in the minds of the reader. This lack of closure at the end of the narrative is a literary device used to involve the reader in the ideological conflict that propels the real plot of the book: Jonah’s sense of justice versus God’s boundless mercy. The final scene blurs the narrative frame, so that the world of the text reaches out and envelops the world of the reader, forcing them to ask whose perspective they will adopt.”

Crouch, Walter B. (1994). “To Question and End, To End and Question: Opening and Closure in the Book of Jonah.” *Sage Journals*, vol. 19, 62. 112.

“[T]he final scene is so skillfully designed that when Jonah insists on Yahweh’s free pity, he cannot really avoid simultaneously conceding to his God the forgiving mercy he has extended to the pagans. But the narrator leaves the readers to draw this harmonizing conclusion themselves. Even the most morosely obstinate of them can hardly do other than—in Jonah’s place—respond with gratitude to their God’s final question.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [\*Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary\*](#). Augsburg Fortress. 88.

“The ‘surprise’ gap at the beginning of the story, with regard to Jonah’s motive for running away, is filled in at the conclusion, when Jonah impeaches the Lord’s grace and compassion as the reason for his flight (4:2), and even more so in the last verse of the book, in which the Lord justifies His decision to show mercy for Nineveh. As Meir Sternberg argues, the impression conveyed by the start of the story is that God is wrathful and punitive. As for Jonah and his flight, we mistakenly believe that the recalcitrant prophet ‘is too tenderhearted to carry a message of doom to a great city. He obviously protests against a wrathful God not with words, like Abraham or Moses or Samuel, but with his feet.’ But the last verses of the book show that we had it backwards: Jonah does not flee because God is a wrathful God, but because He is a merciful God.

The Lord's reaction to the Ninevites' penance—"When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God repented of the evil which He had said he would do to them; and He did not do it" (3:10)—clearly echoes 'the Lord repented of the evil which he thought to do to his people' (Exod 32:14). Thus the book of Jonah teaches us that the Lord's mercy is not reserved exclusively for 'His people' but extends to all of His creation, including its animals, who (unlike Jonah) are not only obedient agents of his will in this story, but also, along with humans, objects of his mercy."

Shemesh, Yael (2010). "'And Many Beasts' (Jonah 4:11): The Function and Status of Animals in the Book of Jonah." *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol. 10. 22

You, Jonah,  
how low  
how deep  
will you go  
to secure  
sleep?

You, Jonah,  
how high  
will you fare  
hoping I  
will ignore  
you there?

You, Jonah,  
how far  
will you aim  
your mariner  
to protect your name  
from my claim?

You! Jonah!

And Jonah stalked  
to his shaded seat  
and waited for God  
to come around  
to his way of thinking.  
And God is still waiting  
for a host of Jonahs  
in their comfortable houses  
to come around  
to his way of loving.

Carlisle, Thomas John (1968). [\*You! Jonah!\*](#) Eerdmans.

## Reflection Question

As you ponder the end of Jonah, why do you think the book ends with a question?